

To: PPS Board of Education
From: Kat Davis, Climate Justice Advisor
CC: Deborah Kafoury, Chief of Staff
RE: Climate Crisis Response, Climate Justice and Sustainable Practices Policy Annual Update
Date: April 28, 2026

Introduction

The purpose of this memo is to provide an annual update on the implementation of the Climate Crisis Response, Climate Justice and Sustainable Practices Policy (CCRP) (APPENDIX A). This memo will review high-level progress made on 2025-2026 policy implementation, successes, challenges, and recommendations to meet the ambitious goals in our commitment to the community.

Context

In March 2022, the Portland Public Schools Board of Education (the Board) unanimously adopted the Climate Crisis Response, Climate Justice, and Sustainable Practices Policy. This policy commits PPS to immediately mobilize resources to reduce the impact of climate change, recognized as one of the most ambitious public school climate action policies in the nation[1]. Beyond responsibility for greenhouse gas (GHG) emissions, the policy centers frontline communities[2] in advancing climate resilience, developing a climate justice education, and to connect students, parents, teachers, staff, and community partners as leaders in climate solutions. This policy requires the advancement of District planning to consider the disproportionate impacts of climate change on the vulnerable members of our community, and recognizes our responsibility to attend to our students' mental health, wellness and emotional challenges that come from anticipating and experiencing extreme climate events. With this commitment, PPS can show our students what a future of climate solutions looks like, creating opportunities for excellence despite a changing climate.

To advance the CCRP objectives, PPS continues to strengthen an intentional and focused strategic approach. In 2024-2025 Climate Crisis Response Committee highlighted the following as key successes from the 2024-2025 school year:

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[1] CCRP is highlighted on the NAAEE District Climate Policies & Resolutions site, and this Sierra Club article describes CCRP as a landmark policy.
[2] Communities that experience the 'first and worst' impacts of climate change: those experiencing systemic injustice—including people of color, people with disabilities, immigrants, people with lower incomes, those in rural areas, and indigenous people—and face a legacy of systemic inequity that impacts their living and working places, the quality of their air and water, and their economic opportunities.



- **Launch of the Student Climate Awareness Survey**: Led by the Climate Crisis Response Committee student representatives, the inaugural survey received over 250 responses from high school students across the district, and captures student awareness of climate action at PPS and feelings of knowledge and efficacy toward participating in climate solutions. This survey is now an annual practice to capture changes in how students feel about the district's climate actions over time.
- **Continued support for electrification of schools:** With the 2025 Bond, PPS is modernizing the remaining three high schools. Given the increasing costs of construction, the Board weighed cost-saving measures for these projects. The Board decided to maintain a commitment to build fully electric comprehensive high schools, honoring the goals of the climate policy and taking a significant step toward reaching the district's 2030 GHG reduction goals.

The CCRC identified the following 2024-2025 deliverable wins:

- **Launch of the Climate Policy Public Dashboard:** Interactive public dashboard with year over year quantitative and qualitative updates on activities that advance the integration of the CCRP into district operations.
- **Digital Showcase of Student Projects:** Interactive map on the Climate Justice website that highlights the project descriptions for each PCEF student project proposal.
- **Community-Centered Climate Action Design Team Report:** In Spring 2024, the Climate Justice department partnered with the Innovation Studio to lead an intensive community engagement session to understand the opportunities to increase student efficacy amidst the climate crisis. In Fall 2024, the design team recommendations report was published and the Climate Justice team began implementation of recommendations.
- **Decarbonization Prioritization Tool:** The PPS Climate Justice and Sustainability teams contracted with PAE, New Building Institute, and Oh! Planning and Design to develop a comprehensive tool to support PPS leadership in prioritizing capital projects that advance the decarbonization goals while also taking into account equity, health and wellness in order to strategically advance bond work and maintenance projects to meet the 2030 and 2040 GHG reduction goals.

To continue advancing policy progress, at the June 2025 Board meeting, the CCRC recommended the following:

I. **Align climate work with PPS priority goals** to continue making progress on climate policy scopes despite decreasing resources and staff capacity.
II. **Embed transparency and engagement tools** to increase accessibility of information about progress towards the climate policy goals.



III. **Preserve and scale climate programs** to continue the progress made since the climate policy was adopted and to prevent progress from stagnating or reversing.
IV. **Institutionalize student voice** via pathways for student engagement and leadership to directly center students in scopes that impact the climate policy.
V. **Expand and redesign the PPS volunteer program** to increase staff capacity for high-value climate action activities.

Given limited resources, prioritization of the 75+ objectives within the Climate Crisis Response Policy (CCRP) is critical to ensure alignment with leadership's vision and operational capacity. To support these priorities, the Climate Justice Advisor created a high-level framework to prioritize the implementation of systems-wide policy scopes and to establish a district-wide process for tracking progress. The strategic priorities for 2025-2026 included:

- **Integrate the Decarbonization Roadmap** into district operations.
- **Increase support systems** for student action and empowerment.
- **Integrate climate literacy** into curriculum adoptions processes.
- **Increase accessibility and transparency** to information on climate action.

A core theme of this strategy is to integrate climate policy goals into existing district scopes and position functions. As the district continues to navigate resource constraints, aligning the scope of this policy with district-wide strategic initiatives to achieve Board goals and student outcomes is increasingly important to ensure the sustainability and accountability of the policy scopes.

Major 2025–2026 Policy Milestones at a Glance

Decarbonization:

As highlighted in the Decarbonization Prioritization Roadmap (APPENDIX B), due to the commitment to build all-electric high school modernizations with the 2025 bond, PPS is projected to reach the 2030 GHG reduction goal – reduce emissions by 50% from the 2019 baseline[3].

Engagement, Resilience, and Wellness:

The Climate Friendly Public Schools Program, funded by the Portland Clean Energy Fund (PCEF), has grown this year, with 100% of eligible schools (37) submitting project proposals by the deadline. This program provides $10,000 to every PPS K-8, middle school and high school for student-led climate action projects. These schools receive these funds every year for five years, starting with the 24-25 school year. Over 2,700 students have been involved

[3] Contingent on PGE making progress on their decarbonization goals.



in the 25-26 project development, and student groups anticipate engaging nearly 20,000 students in their project activities. Targeted partnerships with community organizations such as the Ecoschool Network and Future Climate Collective provide additional classroom capacity through coordination of adult volunteers to support students in high-need communities for project development and implementation. Projects span a wide array of interests, including student advocacy in Salem, career fairs and workshops, field trips to learn new skills, adding accessible biking infrastructure, and much more. Read more about all of this year's Student Climate Projects on the interactive dashboard.

In addition, the Climate Justice team is working closely with the CCRC Student Representatives to provide support in operationalizing and elevating the Climate Crisis Student Survey (survey open April 1 - 30, 2026).

Pillar One: Reduce Environmental Impact and Costs

To reduce environmental impact and costs, PPS strategically invests capital funds that achieve the greatest emissions reduction while increasing environmental health and safety. Designing and constructing new low-carbon schools and renovations that are energy-efficient, resilient, and adaptable is a top priority, as is maximizing reductions in greenhouse gas emissions from district operations, maintenance, transportation and facilities management. Additionally, advancing green schoolyards projects increases carbon sequestration and resilience to climate extremes. Below are progress metrics towards these goals for the 2025-2026 school year:

Energy Conservation

After years of phased upgrades, PPS has now completed LED lighting installations across all district buildings, significantly improving energy efficiency and reducing long-term operational costs.

Transportation

In Spring 2023, PPS celebrated purchasing the first two electric school buses. Just three years later, thanks to generous grants from PGE, PPS now owns 10 electric school buses. In addition, with an EPA grant, the district's primary bus contractor, First Student, has purchased 17 electric buses to utilize in PPS's service. An additional 3 PPS-owned electric buses are secured and on the way. In a celebration of active transportation opportunities, this year 59 schools participated in Safe Routes to Schools (SRTS) programming, with 76% of students in grades PK-8 engaged in a SRTS program.

Waste reduction



PPS continues to incorporate waste reduction practices across the district through the universal adoption of back-of-house composting in all school kitchens. In partnership with the City of Portland, educators also delivered more than 50 classroom lessons focused on waste reduction and sustainability practices.

Green Schoolyards

Momentum continues to build around greener, more accessible outdoor spaces, with multiple schools advancing vision plans and implementation efforts. This year, 13 schools actively developed schoolyard vision plans while additional sites moved into implementation planning. Expanded volunteer events have supported ongoing maintenance, alongside tangible improvements such as asphalt removal at Vestal, Peninsula, and Chief Joseph. Maintenance of these spaces will be greener as well, with the transition of 100% of PPS leaf-blowers to fully electric. Partnerships for outdoor learning have also grown, reaching three additional schools.

Pillar Two: Improve Health and Wellness

Climate change disproportionately impacts the vulnerable members of our communities. Implementation of this policy prioritizes serving people with disabilities, communities of color, and other vulnerable populations. The district is actively addressing climate-related impacts on health, safety, and wellness to strengthen resilience and improve preparedness for extreme weather events. This includes piloting emergency cooling measures during a fall heat wave and expanding communication with students, families, and staff about heat and air quality conditions. PPS is also leveraging significant new investments – including a $19.9 million Portland Clean Energy Fund SP16 grant and a $25.6 million award through the Multnomah Education Service District – to improve thermal comfort, upgrade HVAC systems, and expand greening of schoolyards across the district.

Pillar Three: Provide Effective Environmental and Sustainability Education

Through its climate policy, PPS is committed to educating and empowering students as leaders in a just transition to a sustainable and restorative future. The district is working to ensure all students build environmental literacy and understand the connections between their daily actions and the natural world, using community-based learning and civic engagement to support the goals outlined in the Graduate Portrait. This initiative aims for PPS graduates to not only understand the causes and consequences of climate change and climate justice, but also to actively engage in developing and applying climate solutions.

Building on this vision, the Climate Justice team is aligning district efforts with the Oregon Department of Education K–12 Climate Literacy Standards (published December 2025), supporting a review of high school science curriculum and informing the adoption of updated



social studies materials to strengthen climate literacy integration. At the same time, PPS is expanding student learning opportunities by advancing the Climate Justice high school elective from a one-semester course to a full-year offering, allowing students to earn a full science credit while deepening their engagement with climate solutions.

Challenges:

In the spirit of transparency and accountability, in order to prioritize limited staff capacity and resources, some scopes shifted this year that were previously celebrated. Due to budget reductions, the contract for the software that hosted the climate policy dashboard was not renewed. An alternative solution for public-facing climate policy tracking and reporting is still in development. With staff turn-over, there was a staffing gap in the Energy and Sustainability department which limited accessibility to specific emissions data. With the start of a new Energy and Sustainability Manager, PPS will restore public visibility of emissions and utility data.

Additionally, the Climate Justice team made the challenging decision to not continue the Climate Justice Youth Advisory space this year. In previous years, the CJYA provided a pathway for passionate high school students from across the district to gather at the central office with the Climate Justice team to learn about climate justice, share their thoughts and experiences on how PPS is implementing the CCRP, and to plan education and engagement activities for their peers. With limited resources, the Climate Justice team chose to channel more support into the PCEF student climate projects rather than try to focus on both spaces. Should resources and capacity increase in the future, restarting this space should be a top priority.

Moving Forward

PPS has made a targeted effort to operationalize the goals in the CCRP in design standards for construction, advancing the Pillar One policy goals and decarbonization efforts. With Oregon HB 3365 in 2025, ODE is now providing guidance to better advance the Pillar 3 climate literacy goals in alignment with the PPS Instructional Framework. As PPS moves into a year of restructuring and re-alignment, there is an opportunity to more intentionally focus on the Pillar 2 climate resilience and wellness goals.

Due to ongoing budget challenges, the Climate Justice Advisor position has been eliminated for the 2026–2027 fiscal year. To support continuity and uphold the commitments of this board policy, the Climate Justice Advisor will synthesize recommendations from the Climate Crisis Response Committee, findings from the Student Climate Survey, and key lessons learned into a strategic implementation proposal for PPS leadership for the 2026–2027 school year.